Rs 4.3 lakh crore in 2021-22—nearly 14 per cent higher than its GSDP in 2020-21. Between 2019-20 and 2020-21, the GSDP grew at just over 9 per cent.

The state is now strategically positioned to massively upscale its economic trajectory. It's at the centre stage of nearly two billion consumers on ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) and BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal) markets with 1.3 billion MT of proven resources such as four refineries and substantial natural gas reserves. Also, once insurgency-infested, Assam has now begun to reap the fruits of a peaceful environment, political stability and growing attention from the BJP-led Union government.

ASSAM'S AVERAGE GROWTH RATE HAS BEEN HIGHER THAN THE NATIONAL AVERAGE FOR 7 YEARS NOW

Yet, Sarma is unwilling to rest on past laurels and is in a tearing hurry to turn around the Assam story—traditionally known as one of the poorest states in India. He has continued the trend of increased budgetary expenditure in the past five years—more than doubling from Rs 41,931 crore in 2016-17 to Rs 1.12 lakh crore. The increased expenditure has been dovetailed strategically into social as well as infrastructure sectors in the past few years. "There was no other alternative," says the CM. "We have a long road to cover. When Prime Minister Modi has been working round the clock for the progress of the country, it's our responsibility to do what is in our limited capacity to strengthen his hand."

Not surprisingly, the capital expenditure in the state almost tripled from Rs 4,919 crore in 2015-16 to Rs 14,630 crore now. With the government planning to build 3,000 km of all-weather roads and upgrade 1,350 km of roads, Sinha believes that Assam will have the best road network in the country by 2025. The state now boasts of an extensive network of roads and highways—3,800 km of national highways, 2,500 km of state highways, and 4,400 km of district roads. The government has also started the ambitious 'Asom Mala' programme in line with the 'Bharat Mala Project', the objective being to build robust high-speed corridors with safety standards.

The state also has a network of over 2,400 km of railway lines for the seamless movement of freight and passengers. The National Waterway on the Brahmaputra connects the state to the Chittagong and Mongla ports in Bangladesh, opening up increasing prospects of cross-border trade. Another significant waterway is the National Waterway 16 on the Barak River in south Assam. With six operational airports, Assam

MOST IMPROVED BIG STATES OVERALL

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 2,000	RANK 2021	RANK 2020	RANK 2019	RANK 2018
1	ASSAM	1,185.3	2	1	1	1
2	ANDHRA PRADESH	1,165.2	6	2	2	8
3	MADHYA PRADESH	1,152.5	3	3	3	3
4	BIHAR	1,147.3	1	9	4	7
5	GUJARAT	1,145.7	4	11	13	17
6	JHARKHAND	1,140.8	10	7	6	6
7	TELANGANA	1,123.3	5	10	9	14
8	UTTAR PRADESH	1,107.6	13	17	7	4
9	RAJASTHAN	1,086.4	14	13	14	11
10	WEST BENGAL	1,061.7	7	4	8	13
11	KARNATAKA	1057.0	17	15	12	9
12	ODISHA	1,043.0	12	8	11	10
13	MAHARASHTRA	1,039.7	8	14	15	18
14	HARYANA	1,019.1	9	5	17	15
15	CHHATTISGARH	1,007.0	11	6	5	5
16	TAMIL NADU	1,004.4	16	19	19	16
17	UTTARAKHAND	979.1	19	20	20	19
18	PUNJAB	924.0	15	16	16	20
19	KERALA	897.9	20	18	18	21
20	HIMACHAL PRADESH	897.7	18	12	10	12